

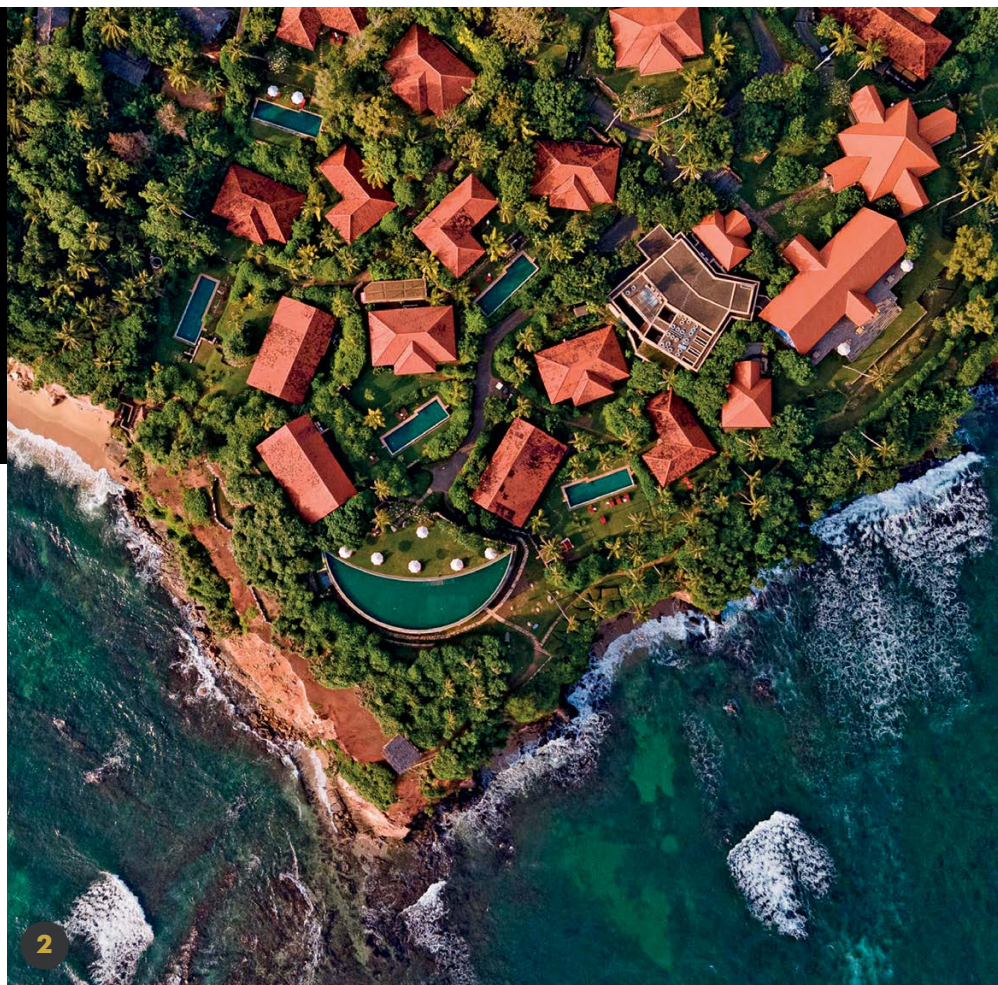
between them. Some famous Relais & Châteaux restaurants include San Diego-based three-Michelin star restaurant Addison, two-Michelin star Italian restaurant Arnolfo in Siena, and three-Michelin star Spanish restaurant in San Sebastian called Akelarre. In India, Mumbai-based Masque is the only standalone restaurant to be a part of Relais & Châteaux.

Typically, Relais & Châteaux guests are in their 40s. “We have around 600 villas, so we are focussed on families. Our properties are generally outside the cities. Nearly 80 per cent of all our activity is dedicated to family, friends and standalone couples or individual travellers,” says Gardinier. “We’re not only selling you rooms, we’re selling the

experience... of travelling. It’s not just about being on the beach and spending hours on it; it’s the possibility to explore the world,” says the Parisian hotelier, the youngest of three brothers running the Gardinier group that comprises businesses across France.

I **N INDIA, SIX** properties are part of Relais & Châteaux. These include Bengaluru-based Shreyas Retreat, Ahilya By the Sea in Goa, Mihirgarh and Suján in Rajasthan and Niraamaya Surya Samudra and The Malabar House in Kerala.

Gardinier says he is keen on more members from India, but finding the right property is essential. Established in 1954 and now operating in 65 countries, the non-profit Relais & Châteaux is fussy about which property it lets into its “family”. Gardinier says each year it receives more than 500 applications globally but accepts an average of only 20 members. “We try to find the best local experience offered by the operator. But most of the time, we refuse anyone who is not connected with the local culture of the place.”



1. AT THE HELM Laurent Gardinier, President, Relais & Châteaux

2. IN THE LAP OF NATURE Cape Weligama on the southern coast of Sri Lanka has 39 suites and villas